



against the 42-time champion.

Photo sessions and autograph sprees continued for well over an hour. Even after coach Usman Gani summoned the players for a team meeting — reminding them that the ultimate target was still a week away — it took captain Akshay Wadkar, highest run-scorer Yash Rathod, and leading wicket-taker Harsh Dubey an extra 10 minutes to reach the dressing room, as eager fans clamoured for autographs.

For the first four days of the semifinal, however, the crowd at the VCA Stadium had primarily turned up for a glimpse of India's T20I captain, Suryakumar Yadav, who was part of the opposition camp (**pic below, facing page**). With Suryakumar, former India captain Rahane, T20I star Shivam Dube, and all-rounder Shardul Thakur among the marquee names, the match generated an enthusiastic response from spectators. On day three — a state holiday marking Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj's birth anniversary — well over 3,000 fans flocked to Jamtha. While many travelled from neighbouring districts, some even made the journey from Madhya Pradesh, crossing the State border to witness the contest. One particularly devoted Suryakumar fan, who had travelled from Chhindwara — approximately 130 km from the stadium — had gone the extra mile by painting his entire body in the

tricolour. Instead of the Ashoka Chakra, he emblazoned "Surya" in blue across his chest. His dedication was rewarded when Suryakumar stopped to take a selfie with him while leaving the stadium after the day's play.

Amol Karhadkar

Semifinal for the ages

It was a pleasant morning at the Narendra Modi Stadium, with a crisp breeze sweeping across the ground as play resumed on the fifth day of the Ranji Trophy semifinal between Gujarat and Kerala. But despite the refreshing weather, the players from both sides were feeling the heat — 27 runs and three wickets separated them from a place in the final.

"*Nammal ithu jeikum* (We will win this)," the Kerala team manager had declared on the eve of the decisive day. But the situation suggested otherwise. The two batters at the crease had already put on 91 runs, looking rock-solid in defence. Gujarat, you could say, was firmly in the driver's seat.

Kerala's preparations had been meticulous. Four spinners worked tirelessly in the nets before play began, with close-in catchers ready to pounce on any low-flying chances. The wicketkeeper honed his reflexes, anticipating sharp turn from the surface. Under head coach Amay Khurasiya, a former India international from Madhya Pradesh,

Put it in the Louvre: Jalaj Saxena triumphantly holds up Salman Nizar's helmet — the very one that deflected Arzan Nagwaswalla's slog-sweep, sending the ball gently into Sachin Baby's hands. **R.V. MOORTHY**

Kerala had transformed into one of the grittiest outfits in the competition. The support staff spoke of his strict methods — only those willing to fully commit to his philosophy found a place in the side. Throughout the match, Khurasiya remained deeply involved, passing notes scribbled on small pieces of paper to the batters whenever possible. In the dugout, coordinated claps rang out, lifting the energy of those battling it out in the middle. Team meetings were a daily ritual after play, though the staff revealed that little was actually spoken. Instead, the coach chose to inspire his players with motivational videos — one featuring former India football captain Sunil Chhetri stood out in particular.

A few overs into the final morning, twin strikes from Aditya Sarwate sparked wild celebrations in the dugout. "*Oru ball madhi* (One ball is enough)," became the rallying cry from the bench. But Gujarat's last pair refused to surrender easily, stretching the contest to its very limits. Then, with just two runs needed, Arzan Nagwaswalla's attempted slog-sweep took a deflection off the helmet of Salman Nizar at short leg and lobbed gently to Sachin Baby. Kerala's players erupted in unrestrained joy — Sarwate sprinted across the field, high-fiving his skipper along the way. Salman, still dazed from the blow, collapsed to the ground, engulfed in bear hugs from his jubilant teammates. Amidst the euphoria, Khurasiya remained composed. He raised his palm toward the staff, revealing the number two written on it — a prediction he had made the night before. He had confidently stated that Kerala would either take the lead by six runs or just two. In the end, Kerala's fate unfolded just as he had foreseen.

Anish Pathiyil